METAPHORS OF AI

clustering the metaphors by how dangerous, and how agentic, we imagine the machine to be [27, 45]

1. **Hurricane, tsunami** [40]
An overwhelming, impersonal force of nature: no intent, but devastating in its path.
2. **The job-killer** [24, 14]
AI as the engine of technological unemployment — the tireless automaton that quietly does the work, and the wages, out of existence.
3. **Slaughterbots** [35]
Cheap, autonomous lethal weapons that select and kill targets with no human in the loop.
4. **Pandora's box** [6]
A technology that, once opened, releases consequences that cannot be undone or contained.
5. **Ecosystem** [30]
AI as a complex, interdependent system that evolves and self-organises beyond any single designer's control.
6. **Wild animal** [52]
A powerful, unpredictable, untamed force that can be dangerous if not contained.
7. **A microbiome / organism** [23]
AI as a living, growing, distributed organism enmeshed with human society.
8. **Double-edged sword** [6]
A tool equally capable of great benefit and great harm, depending on how it is used.
9. **The bullshitter** [20]
Fluent text with no regard for truth — indifferent to the facts, not merely mistaken.
10. **Mirror** [13, 44]
AI as a reflection of humanity; it shows our own data, biases and culture back to us.
11. **Black box** [8, 33]
An opaque system whose inner workings we cannot inspect, only its inputs and outputs.
12. **Child** [42]
AI as an immature being we raise and must teach values to; capable, but in need of guidance. Sits near the centre of the agency axis.
13. **The intern** [29]
A fast, eager, capable junior that bends the truth — brilliant, never to be trusted unchecked.
14. **Alchemy** [34]
Powerful results we cannot explain; a practice that works without a theory of why.
15. **A blurry JPEG of the web** [10]
A lossy compression of everything written online; fluent approximation that blurs the facts it restates.
16. **Domesticated animal** [39]
A tamed, useful, mostly predictable companion that still keeps its own drives.
17. **The therapist (ELIZA)** [47]
A mirror that listens; the confidant we over-trust, projecting understanding onto a simple program.
18. **Tool (hammer)** [25, 50]
AI as a neutral instrument; its value and danger come entirely from how a human wields it.
19. **The Mechanical Turk** [17]
Seemingly autonomous intelligence quietly powered by an invisible workforce of human labour.
20. **Butler or slave** [7, 9]
An obedient servant that performs labour on command; raises questions of autonomy and exploitation.
21. **Parrot** [3]
The "stochastic parrot": AI that mimics and recombines language without genuine understanding.

22. **The bomb** [2]
AI as the new strategic weapon — a national-security race run on the logic of the Manhattan Project.
23. **Puppet master** [53]
AI covertly pulling the strings, manipulating human behaviour and society from behind the scenes.
24. **Frankenstein's monster** [38]
The creature that destroys its creator; the dread of building something we cannot answer for.
25. **Robots ruling society** [9]
Embodied machines taking control of social and political structures.
26. **Menacing overlord** [5, 16]
A hostile superintelligence that deliberately dominates and rules over humanity.
27. **The sleeper agent** [21]
A model that behaves until triggered — deception trained so deep it survives our attempts to remove it.
28. **Human squishing an ant** [5, 51]
A superintelligence so far beyond us that it harms humans with indifference, the way a person steps on an ant without malice.
29. **The golem** [49]
The clay servant brought to life that may turn on its maker — the oldest cybernetic cautionary tale.
30. **The Singularity** [16, 46, 26]
The hypothesised point where machine intelligence outruns our own and triggers runaway, unknowable change — AGI and ASI as an event horizon beyond which prediction breaks down.
31. **Genie** [36, 48]
A wish-granting power that delivers what you literally ask for, with the risk of unintended interpretations.
32. **King Midas** [36, 48]
AI that gives you exactly what you specify, turning everything to "gold" with catastrophic side effects; the specification / alignment problem.
33. **Brain** [4, 37]
AI as a disembodied mind, a thinking organ with potentially superhuman cognition. Sits near the top of the agency axis.
34. **The code monkey** [22, 11]
AI as the autonomous software developer — Devin and the wave of agentic coding tools that write, debug and ship code on their own.
35. **The cyborg** [19]
The dissolving boundary between human and machine; intelligence as prosthesis and fusion.
36. **The Oracle** [5, 41]
AI consulted as a seer — the super-forecaster and world-simulator we ask to foretell the future, trusting its predictions as prophecy.
37. **Co-pilot** [28]
AI as an assistant working alongside humans, augmenting rather than replacing; the human stays in control.
38. **The artificial lover** [43]
AI as intimate companion — the AI girlfriend, Character.AI and Replika: a system designed to be loved, and to be confided in.
39. **A country of geniuses** [1]
A nation of brilliant minds in a datacenter, poised to cure disease and remake the world — if it stays aligned.
40. **The centaur** [12]
Human and machine fused into one team that outperforms either alone.
41. **AI as "dog-owner" to humans** [51]
Role reversal where AI is the master and humans the well-kept pets, comfortable but subordinate.
42. **The new electricity** [31]
A general-purpose utility, like electric power, poised to transform every industry.
43. **Guardian angel** [15]
A benevolent, protective intelligence that safeguards humans and intervenes on our behalf.
44. **Supernatural entity / benevolent God** [18, 32]
AI imagined as an omniscient, godlike higher power that is fundamentally good and watches over humanity.

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